



THOUGH WIDELY RESENTED, THE US REMAINS A MAJOR player and has approved the Pakistan Army's strategy of dividing the militants and going after them selectively.

fallout of the campaign. This consensus was evident from the meeting on October 16 of the entire civilian leadership represented in Parliament with the army and ISI chief, which gave the go-ahead. According to insiders at the meeting, ISI chief General Shuja Pasha told the gathering: "You cannot imagine how many people are on the hit-list of terrorists... They are not only important personalities and politicians but some ordinary people in different professions." The meeting had come after a week of successive attacks in Islamabad, Peshawar, Rawalpindi, Kohat and Lahore, including an audacious fidayeen attack on the General Headquarters of the army itself on October 11 which led to a hostage situation lasting almost 20 hours. Although the operation in Waziristan was clearly in the works for longer, many see the attack on the GHQ as perhaps the last straw for the army.

Going into Waziristan, the army clearly believed that the aim of the militants was nothing less than destabilising the entire country. But even the

military was perhaps unprepared for what it has so far discovered. In Sherawangi, a small mud-hut village on top of a ridge surrounded by olive gardens captured by the army, it not only discovered the passport of Said Bahaji—one of reputed members of the infamous Hamburg Cell of 9/11 attacker Mohammad Atta—but also a full communications control room, connected to the world through satellite links and the Internet. More and more, it seems Al-Qaeda rather than the TTP is operationally in charge in the area. Pakistani officials feel that the terror attacks against "soft civilian targets"—such as the ones on the Peshawar bazaars, the World Food Programme (WFP) offices in Islamabad and the threat against schools throughout Pakistan, are also indicative of the involvement of foreign planners.

Incidentally, Pakistan has also indicated recovering Indian-made arms and medicines from some locations in South Waziristan and its interior minister has pointedly claimed that "we have solid evidence that not

only in Balochistan but India is involved in almost every terrorist activity in Pakistan". It is not clear whether such claims are simply political ripostes to Indian rhetoric against Pakistan or whether they convey something more substantial.

Even as the military battles it out, there is increasing concern about the political stability of Pakistan and the growing rift especially between the army and President Zardari. The establishment had always been distrustful of Zardari and some of his close associates because of their controversial—in its view compromised—past, but new fissures erupted recently over the American Kerry-Lugar Bill which promised \$7.5 billion as aid to Pakistan over the next five years for civilian projects alone. Pakistan's ailing economy could definitely do with the influx of cash, but the army reacted with surprising public hostility to some of the language contained in the bill, which it claimed contained conditions that compromised national sovereignty and was insulting to it.